

Confound These Formats!

Q In AVI to DVD software, while converting VCD files to DVD format, the audio stream box is blank. It doesn't show the audio formats. VCDs are generally of the DAT file format. Are AVI and DAT of the same type? Please tell me how to convert VCD into DVD format and vice versa.

Vipul Shah

A Audio streams of a DVD usually consist of six audio channels, and are Dolby Digital encoded. To decode the audio, you need to have the appropriate AC3 filters installed. In absence of these codecs, the DVD audio cannot be decoded, so you're unable to see anything in

the audio stream box. You can download the free AC3 filters from <http://ac3filter.sourceforge.net>. Alternatively, you may also download and install DVD players such as CyberLink PowerDVD 6 from www.cyberlink.com or InterVideo WinDVD from www.intervideo.com.

The DAT format is different from AVI. DAT is an implementation of the MPEG-1 format, whereas AVI is the native video format used by Windows. You can use software such as Nero Vision Express (bundled with Nero CD/DVD burning software) to convert VCD to DVD and vice-versa. You can also use TMPGEnc from www.tmpegenc.net/e_download.html.

A There's a setting in the Registry you can change for this purpose. In the Registry Editor, navigate to `HKEY_LOCAL_MACHINE\SOFTWARE\Microsoft\Windows NT\CurrentVersion\Winlogon`. Modify or create a DWORD Value called `PasswordExpiryWarning`. For the value data, enter the number of days before expiration for the nag screen (which asks to change the password) to start appearing. Done!

Looking All Over The Place

Q Whenever I select File > Open in any application and use the Look In section to browse to a location, the application freezes for several minutes. I use Windows XP Professional.

Rohit G

A You'll need to remove unreachable network connections to prevent the dialog box and application from not responding—Windows tries to populate the drop-down list with these unreachable hosts. In Internet Explorer, select Tools > Disconnect Network Drive. Disconnect all network connections that are unreachable. You can know which network connections are unreachable by looking at error messages like "Could not connect to network drive" during XP startup.

Wasted Clicks

Q Ever since I installed the .NET Framework, XP shows me my username on the Welcome screen and prompts me to click on it before I can proceed to the desktop. This is irritating because I am the only user on my computer and I do not use a password.

Shahid Gul

A While the following tweak will make for convenience, it comes at a price: the lack of security. Due to the way it is implemented, anyone with local or remote access to the computer can easily navigate to the Registry key and find out your password—you'll need to add one—since it's stored as a plain text string.

Open the Registry Editor and navigate to `HKEY_LOCAL_MACHINE\SOFTWARE\Microsoft\Windows NT\CurrentVersion\Winlogon`. Modify or create the String Values called `DefaultUserName`, `DefaultPassword`, and `AutoAdminLogon`.

For the first and second, enter the values as the account name and password respectively. Set the third String Value to 1.

Hidden On The CD

Q Is it true that a free Backup utility is bundled with Windows XP Home Edition? My installation does not have any indication to this effect.

Deepak Singh

A No Backup icon is present on the Start menu in Windows XP Home Edition, nor is Backup listed in Add/Remove Programs. It's just necessary to do a manual install: insert the CD and navigate to `[CD Drive]:\VALUEADD\MSFT\NTBACKUP`. Double-click `Ntbackup.msi` to start the Wizard that installs the Backup utility.

Wakey, Wakey!

Q When I boot into my XP computer, I find that on clicking the Start Menu items, they are unresponsive for up to a couple of minutes.

Kiran Raaz

A If you are not a part of a network, run `msconfig` and click the Services tab. Remove the checkmark from Workstation, click OK, and reboot.

If you are a part of a network, open Network Connections in the Control Panel. Right-click your network connection and select Properties. Uncheck File and Print Sharing, and reboot.

In The Beginning

Q I need to run a batch file every time I boot into Windows. The file should run before anyone logs on. I use Windows 2000 Server.

S Venkatraman

A Create a batch file named `Autoexnt.bat` using Notepad—include the commands you want to run at startup in this file. Copy the file you just created, in addition to the `Autoexnt.exe`, `Servmess.dll`, and `Instexnt.exe` files located in the Resource Kit CD-ROM to the `%SystemRoot%\System32` folder. Then run `instexnt` install. You should receive the following message:

CreateService AutoExNT SUCCESS with InterActive Flag turned OFF

To configure the AutoExNT service to run at startup, go to Administrative Tools and click Computer Management. Double-click the Services and Applications branch to expand it, then click Services. Make the AutoExNT service Automatic.